

PART 1 OF 4 - SECTION ONE: PROSE

12TH HSC ENGLISH

MAHARASHTRA BOARD

1.1 An Astrologer's Day, by R. K. Narayan

About the Author

R. K. Narayan (1906-2001), full name Rasipuram Krishnaswami Iyer Narayanaswami, was one of India's most celebrated English-language novelists. He created the fictional South Indian town of Malgudi, the setting for most of his fourteen novels and several story collections. His writing is known for its gentle irony, simplicity and warm, humane humour. His novel 'The Guide' won the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1961.

About the Extract

This short story, from the collection 'An Astrologer's Day and Other Stories' (1947), is a classic example of Narayan's ironic, understated humour and his eye for the ordinary dramas of Indian daily life.

Summary

An astrologer with no real training sets up shop each evening under a tamarind tree in a busy market, relying on guesswork, a striking appearance and a shrewd read of his customers to earn a living. One night, just as he is packing up, a stranger named Guru Nayak stops him and challenges him to prove his skill, betting money on the outcome. In the near-darkness, the astrologer recognises the man from his past and, thinking on his feet, tells him that the person who once stabbed and left him for dead is already dead, killed by a lorry, and warns him never to travel south again or danger awaits.

Guru Nayak, satisfied and relieved, pays up and leaves. That night, at home, the astrologer confesses to his wife that years ago, in a drunken village brawl, he believed he had killed a man and had fled ever since, living under a new identity. Learning that the man is alive lifts a lifelong burden of guilt off his shoulders.

Character Sketch

The Astrologer: Shrewd astrological knowledge
escape a guilt-ridden past

Guru Nayak: Impulsive
is easily convinced and

The Astrologer's Wife
the end.

ogy rather than any real
to earn his living and

nce tried to kill him, but

t until his confession at

Theme / Message

The story explores fate
from a crime of his past
human psychology rather

allow a man to be freed
t its 'success' rests on

Exam Practice Questions

Q1. Why did the astrologer

? (2 marks)

He depended entirely on customer goodwill for his livelihood. Agreeing with what people wanted to hear, and reading their moods and appearance shrewdly, brought him repeat business, so he never revealed that he had no real astrological training.

Q2. What made Guru Nayak trust the astrologer's words? (2 marks)

The astrologer accurately described details of Guru Nayak's past - being stabbed, thrown into a well and left for dead - details the astrologer actually knew firsthand because he was the man responsible. This convinced Guru Nayak the astrologer had genuine supernatural insight.

Q3. Why did the astrologer feel a great burden lift off him? (2 marks)

For years he believed he had killed a man in a village brawl and had fled his home in guilt. Discovering that Guru Nayak, the man he thought he had killed, was alive and had gone away satisfied, relieved him of decades of guilt and fear.

Q4. What is ironic about the story's ending? (2 marks)

The very man the astrologer feared meeting again turns out to be his last customer of the day, and instead of being recognised and taking revenge, Guru Nayak is deceived into believing his enemy is dead - the hunter unknowingly consults his own quarry.

Q5. Bring out the contrast between the astrologer's outward profession and his inner life. (4 marks)

Outwardly, the astrologer projects mystical confidence - sacred ash, a turban, a piercing gaze - and appears to have supernatural powers over others' destinies. Inwardly, he is an ordinary, frightened man who fled his village after a violent mistake, has no real training, and has spent years worried about being caught. The story contrasts his public performance of certainty with his private guilt and fear, showing how appearances can ma

Q6. 'An Astrologer's

The astrologer's entire running away from a extension of his need darkness, he uses th freed only when he le shape an entire life u

Q7. What role does

Narayan builds the st knows - that he and This irony powers bot finding comic, life-like

laborate. (4 marks)

marriage - stems from ess is really an m disguised by t time, and is finally ved act can quietly

ere? (4 marks)

t the astrologer alone s unaware throughout. Narayan's style of y ones.

1.2 On Saying "Please", by A. G. Gardiner

About the Author

Alfred George Gardiner (1865-1946) was a British journalist and essayist who edited the Daily News, London, and wrote regularly under the pen name 'Alpha of the Plough'. His essays are known for their graceful, humorous style and their gentle moral observations on everyday life. Collections include 'Pebbles on the Shore' and 'Many Furrows'.

About the Extract

In this essay, Gardiner reflects on the value of courtesy and good manners in everyday social life, using a real newspaper incident as his starting point.

Summary

Gardiner begins with a news report of a lift-man who was fined for physically throwing out a passenger who refused to say "please." He argues that while the law can punish violence, it cannot legislate good manners - rudeness is not a legal offence, so no court can force people to be courteous. Yet he notes that bad manners spread like a chain reaction: one person's rudeness passes down to the next person they meet, and so on, poisoning the general atmosphere of life more than any crime might.

He then praises a genuinely polite bus conductor he once travelled with, who treated every passenger - young, old, blind, or simply forgetful of their fare - with patience and warmth, making his difficult job easier and spreading goodwill wherever he went. Gardiner concludes that small courtesies like "please" and "thank you" are what keep the "machine of life" running smoothly, and that meeting rudeness with elaborate politeness, as Lord Che

Key Ideas

Law vs. Manners: Th
however hurtful it may f

ower over discourtesy,

Contagion of Manners
with the anecdote of Sir

Gardiner illustrates this

The Polite Conductor
calling" dignified and lig

mour make a "modest

Theme / Message

True civility is a social p
small change that keep
to rudeness with grace

and 'thank you' are the
mand, and responding

Exam Practice Questi

Q1. Why couldn't th

(2 marks)

Discourtesy is not recognised as a legal offence. The law only punishes actions like assault or theft that break definite legal commands; it has no way of legislating tone, manners or private civility.

Q2. How does Gardiner illustrate that bad manners are 'infectious'? (2 marks)

He gives the example of Sir Anthony Absolute bullying Captain Absolute, who then bullies his servant Fag, who in turn kicks the page-boy - showing how one person's rudeness gets passed down the chain to someone else entirely.

Q3. What made the bus conductor's courtesy so effective? (2 marks)

He treated every kind of passenger - the old, the young, children, and even a blind passenger - with patience, warmth and consideration, regardless of the difficulty of his job, which created goodwill and made his own work lighter.

Q4. What lesson does the Lord Chesterfield anecdote teach? (2 marks)

When a rude man refused to step aside for him, Chesterfield stepped into the muddy road with a bow instead of forcing the issue. The anecdote shows that responding to rudeness with exaggerated politeness is a more dignified and complete victory than retaliating with equal rudeness or violence.

Q5. Bring out the contrast Gardiner draws between legal offences and moral offences. (4 marks)

Gardiner distinguishes between offences the law can punish - burglary, assault, theft - which involve a clear breach of a legal command, and offences that are purely moral, like rudeness, haughtiness or an unkind tone, which cause real pain but carry no legal penalty. He argues the pain of a wound to one's self-respect can 'poison a whole day' far more than a physical injury, even though only the physical injury is compensable in law.

Q6. 'Manners maket

The essay shows tha
courtesy. The polite b
temper, while the well
despite his social sta
person, and that they

than by everyday
urely through his good
s as small-minded
he real measure of a

Q7. Why does Gardi

He argues civility is a
between people far m
'you' acknowledges a
rather than one of co
on far more than it de

? (4 marks)

yday give-and-take
g 'please' and 'thank
friendly cooperation
ich society depends

1.3 The Cop and the Anthem, by O. Henry

About the Author

O. Henry (1862-1910), pen name of William Sydney Porter, was an American short-story writer famous for his surprise, twist endings and his blend of humour and pathos, often described as writing with a 'smile with tears.'

About the Extract

One of O. Henry's best-known stories, it follows a homeless man's comic and ultimately ironic attempts to get arrested so he can spend the harsh winter in the warmth and shelter of prison.

Summary

Soapy, a homeless vagabond in New York, decides that getting arrested and sent to the prison on Blackwell's Island is his best defence against the coming winter. He tries several plans: entering a fine restaurant intending to eat without paying (thrown out before he even orders), smashing a shop window in plain view of a policeman (the officer chases someone else instead), eating a full meal at a cheap diner and refusing to pay (the waiters simply throw him out onto the pavement), acting drunk and disorderly in public (the policeman assumes he's just a harmless college student celebrating), and finally stealing a stranger's umbrella in front of a cop (the "victim" backs down, believing it's a misunderstanding).

Defeated and dejected, Soapy wanders near an old church, where the sound of an organ playing an anthem stirs a sudden, powerful memory of his better days - of home, ambition and self-respect. Moved, he resolves to reform his life and find honest work the very next day. At that exact moment, a policeman arrests him for loitering, and he is sent to prison. He has been chasing all along, now granted just when

Character Sketch

Soapy: A homeless man, a criminal; his sudden misfortune under rough circumstances.

He is naturally more unlucky than he seems or change beneath his

Theme / Message

The story is built on the irony of Soapy finally arrested the moment he decides to reform (the church scene) with confidence.

He tries to break the law, yet is caught at the moment of the soul, found in the misfortune.

Exam Practice Questions

Q1. Why did Soapy

Winter was approaching. Soapy decided that Blackwell's Island would be safer than sleeping on

the streets. He sought prison term on the harsh season, which felt

Q2. Why did the policeman not arrest Soapy for breaking the shop window? (2 marks)

Soapy deliberately stood still and even spoke to the policeman after breaking the glass, but the officer assumed that no real culprit would stay behind to chat with the police, and instead chased another man who was running away.

Q3. What change came over Soapy near the church? (2 marks)

Hearing the organ music and anthem reminded him of his earlier life, when he had ambitions, family and self-respect. He felt a strong, sudden urge to reform, give up his degraded lifestyle, and find honest work the next day.

Q4. What is ironic about how the story ends? (2 marks)

Soapy is arrested and sentenced to three months on the island only after he has decided to turn his life around and no longer wants to go to prison - the very moment he abandons crime is the moment fate finally delivers the punishment he had been chasing all along.

Q5. Trace the different ways Soapy tried to get arrested and explain why each attempt failed. (4 marks)

Soapy first tries to eat at a fancy restaurant without paying but is thrown out for his shabby appearance before he can even order. He then smashes a shop window in front of a policeman, who chases an innocent bystander instead of him. Next, he eats a full meal at a cheap diner and admits he cannot pay, but the waiters simply throw him onto the pavement rather than call the police. He then pretends to be drunk and disorderly, but the officer mistakes him for a harmless celebrating student. Finally, he steals a stranger's umbrella in front of a cop, but the 'owner' backs down, assuming a misunderstanding. In each case, circumstance or the assumptions of others save him from the arrest he is actively seeking.

Q6. Discuss the the

Throughout most of the streets, and the outside anthem awakens his Ironically, just as he goes suggesting that outer

and hunger of the church, where the honest effort. lly confined,

Q7. Comment on O.

O. Henry is famous for example. After a string final twist is that he is reversal of expectation signature 'smile with t

s story. (4 marks)

m' is a classic arrested, the story's tends to reform. This es O. Henry's

1.4 Big Data - Big Insights,

About the Author

This is an informational/expository text included in the textbook to build awareness of data science and its career opportunities; no individual author is credited.

About the Extract

A non-fiction, career-oriented text explaining the concept of Big Data and its wide-ranging applications in the modern world.

Summary

The text explains that Big Data refers to the enormous volume of information - measured in petabytes and exabytes - generated whenever people use the internet: liking a post, making an online purchase, browsing a website, or watching a video. Because this data is too vast and varied for ordinary computing methods, Big Data analytics is used to uncover hidden patterns, trends and correlations within it.

The chapter then surveys major real-world uses of Big Data: location tracking (GPS and logistics), weather forecasting and disaster preparedness, healthcare (wearable devices, remote diagnosis, epidemic tracking), banking and finance (fraud detection, high-frequency trading, monitoring illegal trades), sports analytics (performance tracking through sensors and video), targeted advertising (Facebook and Google campaigns), entertainment recommendations (Netflix and YouTube), and personalised education (customised learning based on each student's pattern of progress). It concludes that Big Data itself is neutral - its value depends entirely on how organisations and individuals choose to use it.

Key Applications of B

Sector
Location & Logistics
Weather
Healthcare
Banking & Finance
Sports
Advertising
Entertainment
Education

is
g
es

Theme / Message

The chapter highlights technology's transformative and double-edged role in modern life, and encourages students to recognise the career opportunities emerging in data science, analytics and information technology.

Exam Practice Questions with Model Answers

Q1. What is Big Data? (2 marks)

Big Data refers to extremely large and complex sets of data - measured in petabytes or exabytes - generated from sources like web activity, sales, social media and mobile use, which are too vast for traditional computing methods to process easily.

Q2. How does Big Data help in weather forecasting? (2 marks)

Weather sensors and satellites around the world continuously collect huge amounts of data, which is analysed to predict weather patterns and give advance warning of natural calamities like floods, earthquakes and tsunamis.

Q3. How is Big Data used in the healthcare industry? (2 marks)

Smart watches, wearables and health apps collect ongoing data on heart rate, sleep and activity, allowing better diagnosis, personalised feedback, and 24x7 monitoring of patients, as well as tracking the spread of epidemics.

Q4. How does Big Data benefit the education industry? (2 marks)

It allows institutions to study each student's learning pattern and progress, enabling customised, dynamic learning programmes ne-size-fits-all approach.

Q5. Explain how Bi

Banks and financial i
suitable financial plan
of past attacks, mana
bodies like the Securi
for illegal trades, whil
make split-second bu

arks)

t patterns and design
d by analysing patterns
r load. Regulatory
cs to monitor markets
ial media signals, to

Q6. Big Data has 'tr mentioned in the ch

In healthcare, weara
and epidemic detecti
recommend content,
customised learning
of collected data is a
personalised, efficien

ny three sectors

igns, better diagnosis
ewing history to
performance enables
case, the huge volume
wing more

Q7. What message

Data? (4 marks)

The chapter emphasises that Big Data itself is neither good nor bad; what matters is how organisations and individuals choose to use it. It compares Big Data to 'a genie in our hands', suggesting immense power that can be used for the benefit of mankind (better healthcare, safety, education) or misused (surveillance, manipulation). The message is one of awareness and responsibility - understanding this technology is essential for students considering careers in data-driven fields.

1.5 The New Dress, by Virginia Woolf

About the Author

Virginia Woolf (1882-1941) was an English modernist novelist and essayist, a pioneer of the stream-of-consciousness narrative technique, and an important early feminist voice. Her major works include 'Mrs Dalloway', 'To the Lighthouse' and 'Orlando'.

About the Extract

Taken from her short story collection 'A Haunted House', this story is a fine example of Woolf's stream-of-consciousness technique, tracing one woman's inner anxiety at a high-society party.

Summary

Mabel Waring arrives at a party hosted by Mrs. Dalloway wearing a new, pale-yellow dress she designed herself, based on an old fashion book that belonged to her mother. The moment she enters the room, she becomes convinced the dress looks old-fashioned and ridiculous, and imagines every guest silently mocking her. Through Woolf's stream-of-consciousness narration, we follow Mabel's spiralling self-doubt - her memories of a poor, unglamorous childhood, her lifelong sense of being inferior to others, and her inability to enjoy a single moment of the party.

Even when other guests, like Rose Shaw, compliment her dress, Mabel cannot believe them and instead compares herself to a fly struggling helplessly at the edge of a saucer, unable to escape her own insecurity. Overwhelmed by anxiety and self-criticism, she eventually leaves the party early, privately resolving to change her life and become a different, more confident person - a resolution the story suggests she may never actually keep.

Character Sketch

Mabel Waring: Insecure inferiority complex root

an trapped by a lifelong

Rose Shaw / Other g
though the story hints t

el feels excluded from,
ption that is distorted.

Theme / Message

The story explores so
interior monologue tec
ordinary social occasio

nd reality. Through the
pletely overshadow an

Exam Practice Questi

Q1. Why did Mabel f

As soon as Mrs. Barn
table, Mabel's old sus
entered the room and

party? (2 marks)

tems on the dressing
rew stronger as she

Q2. What does the fly-and-saucer image represent in the story? (2 marks)

Mabel imagines herself as a fly trying helplessly to crawl over the edge of a saucer, unable to escape - this image captures her feeling of being trapped in her own social anxiety and self-doubt, unable to rise above it no matter what she tries.

Q3. Why did Mabel design her own dress instead of buying a fashionable one? (2 marks)

Knowing she could not afford true high fashion, Mabel decided to be 'original' instead, basing her dress on an old Paris fashion book that had belonged to her mother, hoping to achieve a charming, old-fashioned look rather than compete with wealthier guests.

Q4. How did other guests react to Mabel's dress? (2 marks)

Guests like Rose Shaw complimented the dress as 'perfectly charming,' but Mabel could not believe these compliments were sincere, interpreting even kind words through the lens of her own insecurity and imagining mockery behind them.

Q5. Explain how Virginia Woolf uses the stream-of-consciousness technique in this story. (4 marks)

Rather than narrating events in a straightforward, external manner, Woolf takes the reader directly inside Mabel's mind, following her rapid, associative thoughts as they shift between the present party, memories of her childhood, and imagined judgments from other guests. This technique allows the reader to experience Mabel's anxiety exactly as she does - fragmented, repetitive and disproportionate to the actual event - making her inner turmoil, rather than any external drama, the true subject of the story.

Q6. Discuss the theme of inferiority and self-image with reference to 'The New Dress'. (4 marks)

Mabel's crisis is entirely
as a humiliation. Her
herself unfavourably to
that self-image, once
a mind already convinced

et she experiences it
g habit of comparing
. The story suggests
pliments cannot reach

Q7. Comment on the

The 'new dress' is the
herself and be seen
(largely because of her
the central irony of the

deeper wish to reinvent
others see her
The title thus points to
f-worth.

1.6 Into the Wild, by Kiran Purandare

About the Author

Kiran Purandare is a wildlife enthusiast and writer, best known for his book 'Sakha Nagzira', which documents years of close, personal observation of wildlife in the Nagzira forest of Maharashtra. This chapter's second part draws on the experiences of wildlife photographer Shaaz Jung.

About the Extract

This two-part chapter combines a first-person adventure narrative with an account of professional wildlife photography, both centred on encounters with big cats in Indian forests.

Summary

Part I follows the narrator tracking a leopard's movement through the Umbarzara forest by reading the alarm calls of langurs. After meeting a local villager, Raju, and continuing on alone, he loses his way as evening falls. Alert to fresh sloth-bear droppings and the fading light, he searches anxiously for a landmark, eventually spotting a bicycle trail that leads him safely back to the village of Pitezari, where he arrives shaken but relieved, reflecting with quiet wonder on how a forest so close to civilisation can still make a person feel completely lost.

Part II recounts wildlife photographer Shaaz Jung's turning-point experience in the Nagarhole forest, where he witnesses a dramatic confrontation between an ageing leopard and a younger rival. The younger leopard, whom Shaaz names "Scarface," wins the fight and becomes the subject of years of dedicated photography, eventually leading Shaaz to discover and document "Saya," the world's first recorded black panther, and to found a

Key Figures

The Narrator (Kiran)
observation skills help

ose calm, methodical

Shaaz Jung: A wildlife
cats, and later works to

nance to document big

Theme / Message

Both parts of the chapt
vulnerability in nature, t
forest communities and

. They highlight human
d coexistence between

Exam Practice Questi

Q1. How did the nar

He noticed langurs gi
trail, both reliable sig

leopard scat on the
re close by.

Q2. What signs told

He realised the familiar dusky trail had vanished, the position of the setting sun no longer matched his expected direction, and he found himself among unfamiliar hillocks with no landmark to guide him back.

Q3. What discovery finally gave the narrator hope of finding his way back? (2 marks)

He found a red-soil trail with bicycle-wheel marks on it, which told him a village must be nearby, giving him the confidence to keep walking until he reached higher ground and spotted signs of the village of Pitezari.

Q4. Why did Shaaz Jung name the young leopard 'Scarface'? (2 marks)

After winning a fight against an older, weaker leopard, the young leopard appeared the next morning with a deep gash across his face, sitting like the new 'king of the jungle' - the visible scar inspired the name Shaaz gave him.

Q5. Describe the narrator's experience of being lost in the forest and how he coped with it. (4 marks)

As dusk approached, the narrator lost the trail he had been following and realised he was disoriented among unfamiliar hillocks, with fresh sloth-bear droppings nearby adding to the danger. Rather than panicking, he stayed alert, tried to reorient himself using the setting sun, and kept moving with purpose. His persistence paid off when he spotted a bicycle trail, which he correctly read as a sign of a nearby village, and he eventually reached Pitezari safely, exhausted but grateful for the adventure.

Q6. What does Shaaz Jung's story reveal about his commitment to wildlife conservation? (4 marks)

Shaaz gave up a career in finance after a chance encounter with two leopards fighting for dominance left a lasting impression on him. His years of patient, painstaking photography of 'Scarface' led him to further discoveries, including the world's first documented black panther, 'Saya'. Beyond photography, he founded the Buffer Conflict Resolution Centre, which focuses on conservation work, showing that

Q7. Bring out the theme of the chapter. (4 marks)

Despite being an expert, Shaaz was not fully aware of predators like leopards and how they remain vulnerable on the edge of the forest. The invisible presence of predators about how 'there still is a part of the thrill and

the thrill of the chapter. (4

briefly frightened, the observers of nature, and the constant, active closing thought not as a failure but as

1.7 Why We Travel, by Pico Iyer

About the Author

Siddharth Pico Raghavan Iyer is a British-born essayist and travel writer, a long-time essayist for Time magazine, and author of books including 'Video Night in Kathmandu' and 'The Global Soul'.

About the Extract

In this well-known essay, Iyer reflects personally and philosophically on his own lifelong passion for travel, drawing on writers like George Santayana along the way.

Summary

Iyer opens with the idea that we travel first to lose ourselves and then to find ourselves - to open our minds beyond what newspapers can offer and to become, once again, "young fools" willing to slow down and be surprised. Quoting the philosopher George Santayana, he describes travel as an escape into "aimlessness" that sharpens the edge of life.

He questions the popular distinction between "tourist" and "traveller," suggesting the real difference lies between people who carry their fixed assumptions with them everywhere and those who leave them at home. True travel, he argues, "whirls you around" and challenges what you assume to be universal but is really only provincial - local to your own upbringing. In doing so, travel cultivates humility, compassion and a more balanced way of both seeing and feeling the world.

Key Ideas

Losing and finding oneself: Travel is a process of losing understanding to emerge as a more open, honest self.	ore open, honest self-
Tourist vs. Traveller: A tourist carries assumptions behind. A traveller leaves them behind.	ave one's assumptions
Seeing and Feeling: Good travel is both seeing and feeling. The other is either "unconscious" or "unfeeling".	openness; one without

Theme / Message

Travel is presented as a way of shaking off complacency and rediscovering oneself.	- a way of shaking off tions behind.
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Exam Practice Questions

Q1. According to Iyer,

Travel allows us to stretch our eyes to more of the world.

ening our hearts and
see.

Q2. What distinction does Iyer make between a tourist and a traveller?

arks)

He suggests the popular distinction is misleading; the real difference lies between people who leave their fixed assumptions at home and those who carry them everywhere, regardless of whether they call themselves a tourist or a traveller.

Q3. What does George Santayana's quotation add to the essay? (2 marks)

Santayana's idea that we sometimes need to 'escape into open solitudes... into the moral holiday of running some pure hazard' supports Iyer's argument that travel sharpens the edge of life and helps us taste hardship and freedom that routine does not offer.

Q4. Why does Iyer say 'seeing without feeling' or 'feeling without seeing' can both be flawed approaches to travel? (2 marks)

Seeing without feeling can make a traveller cold and uncaring toward what they observe, while feeling without seeing clearly can make them uncritical or naive; genuine travel, he argues, needs a balance of clear observation and emotional openness.

Q5. Explain what Iyer means when he says travel challenges what we assume to be 'universal' but is only 'provincial'. (4 marks)

Growing up in one culture, we often mistake our own local customs, values and assumptions for universal truths about how life works. Travel confronts us directly with different ways of living, revealing that many of our 'certainties' are simply provincial - specific to where we come from, not to humanity as a whole. This first lesson of travel, Iyer suggests, is humbling but essential, because it forces us to question assumptions we never realised we were making.

Q6. Discuss the theme of self-discovery through travel as presented in the essay. (4 marks)

Iyer frames travel as a paradoxical process: we travel to 'lose' our habitual, assumption-bound selves and, through that loss, to 'find' ourselves. In unfamiliar settings, we are stripped of our usual self-understanding and emerge. This idea of travel's greatest value lies not in sightseeing.

Q7. What role does the essay address it? (4 marks)

Iyer suggests that living in our own moral and political usual certainties not only prevents us from seeing precisely what Iyer values but also prevents us from developing a more compassionate and a more compassionate

el address it? (4

uestioned comfort with familiar settings where our usual self-understanding is uncomfortable, is with curiosity, humility

1.8 Voyaging Towards Excellence, by Achyut Godbole

About the Author

Achyut Godbole is a veteran of the Indian IT industry, a prolific author, and a graduate of IIT Bombay. He has written extensively on technology, science, economics and self-development, and led several global software companies over a long career.

About the Extract

In this autobiographical account, Godbole narrates a personal journey of overcoming setbacks and redefining what excellence truly means, from his early days at IIT to his career in Information Technology.

Summary

Godbole recalls arriving at IIT from Solapur with weak spoken English and facing public humiliation from an arrogant classmate who mocked his mistakes. Deeply hurt but unwilling to give up, given his strong academic record, he resolves to master English on his own - reading newspapers and novels, studying phonetics and pronunciation, and practising aloud in front of a mirror until, after about ten months, he gains real fluency and confidence.

At IIT he is transformed further by close contact with a group of exceptionally brilliant students and mentors, which humbles him and sparks a lifelong hunger for knowledge across science, philosophy, economics and the arts, far beyond his coursework. After IIT, he takes an unconventional path - social work with Sarvodaya, imprisonment during a peaceful satyagraha, and financial struggle - before building a long, highly successful career in Information Technology, eventually leading global software companies. He credits humility, curiosity, teamwork and

n of life."

Key Life Lessons

Overcoming Setback
rather than despair.

lined self-improvement

Lifelong Curiosity: Co

d his formal syllabus.

Redefining Success:
marks, titles or wealth a

continual learning - not

Theme / Message

The narrative celebrate
see genuine 'excellenc
score.

ning, urging readers to
vement or examination

Exam Practice Questi

Q1. What incident m

ks)

An arrogant, fluent-English-speaking classmate mocked and corrected nearly every sentence he spoke before insulting him and walking away, leaving Godbole humiliated but determined to prove himself instead of giving up.

Q2. How did Godbole train himself to speak fluent English? (2 marks)

He began reading English newspapers and novels, studied etymology and phonetics to understand correct pronunciation, and practised speaking in front of a mirror repeatedly, correcting his own mistakes until he became confident.

Q3. How did his group of friends at IIT change Godbole's outlook? (2 marks)

Meeting exceptionally brilliant students, researchers and professors from IIT, TIFR and BARC humbled him and showed him what real brilliance meant, sparking a lasting curiosity about subjects far beyond his own engineering coursework.

Q4. What unconventional path did Godbole take after graduating from IIT? (2 marks)

Instead of immediately pursuing a lucrative career, he joined a non-violent social movement with Sarvodaya, participated in a peaceful satyagraha for which he went to jail for ten days, and worked a low-paying supervisory job before eventually settling into a long career in Information Technology.

Q5. Describe how Godbole overcame his early setback at IIT and what it taught him. (4 marks)

After being publicly humiliated over his weak spoken English, Godbole refused to let the incident define him, reasoning that his strong academic record proved his ability. He devised a disciplined self-training plan - reading extensively, studying phonetics, and practising daily in front of a mirror - and within about ten months became a genuinely confident English speaker, a skill that later helped him negotiate international business deals worth millions of dollars. The episode taught him that setbacks can be turned into motivation through

Q6. What values do

Godbole highlight to leading by example rather than only as employee treating knowledge as technical skill.

leadership? (4 marks)

a large organisation; uses as friends rather than he developed at IIT - career as any

Q7. How does the title

The title frames excellence made up of setbacks, to a confident global language, knowledge as a lifelong process of learning

narrative? (4 marks)

an ongoing 'voyage' of a humiliated student's movement, whether in that real excellence is

Quick Revision - Section One (Prose)

Chapter	Author	Type	Core Theme
1.1 An Astrologer's Day	R. K. Narayan	Short story	Guilt, fate and irony
1.2 On Saying "Please"	A. G. Gardiner	Essay	Courtesy and civility
1.3 The Cop and the Anthem	O. Henry	Short story	Irony of fate; freedom vs. confinement
1.4 Big Data - Big Insights		Informational text	Technology, data and career awareness
1.5 The New Dress	Virginia Woolf	Short story	Self-image, insecurity and social anxiety
1.6 Into the Wild	Kiran Purandare	Personal narrative / Adventure	Adventure, wildlife and conservation
1.7 Why We Travel	Pico Iyer	Essay	Travel, self-discovery and open-mindedness
1.8 Voyaging Towards Excellence	Achyut Godbole	Autobiographical narrative	Perseverance, humility and lifelong learning